

ADCLOD Podcast Series with Social Impact Founders

Episode 9: Vishal Talreja, Dream a Dream

Neharika Vohra: Welcome to the ADCLOD podcast series with social impact founders, an initiative by the Ashank Desai Centre for Leadership and Organisational Development at IIM Ahmedabad. In this podcast, we document and celebrate the leadership journeys of India's homegrown social entrepreneurs who have built impactful institutions from the ground up.

Neharika Vohra: In today's episode, we have the privilege of speaking with Vishal Talreja, social entrepreneur, educator, poet, and one of the most original voices in India's education transformation movement. Vishal co-founded Dream a Dream in 1999, along with eleven others, and has since built it into a nationally and globally recognised organisation working to empower children and young people from vulnerable backgrounds to overcome adversity and flourish in a fast-changing world. Over more than two decades, Dream a Dream has trained 44,000 educators and impacted more than 2.2 million children through its direct delivery programmes and strategic partnerships with state governments in Delhi, Jharkhand, Karnataka, Telangana and Uttarakhand. Its landmark partnership with the Delhi government introduced a Happiness Curriculum that reached millions of school children. Vishal is an Ashoka Fellow, an Eisenhower Fellow and a Salzburg Global Fellow. He has co-authored the book **When We Thrive, Our World Thrives**, and published a book of poems, **My Soul Stirring**.

Neharika Vohra: Vishal, welcome to our podcast. It's a privilege and an honour to have you here.

Vishal Talreja: Thank you, Professor Vohra. It's an honour to be here with you on this one.

Neharika Vohra: Thank you. I think it's mutual that we're both happy to be talking to each other. Vishal, could you give us a picture of what Dream a Dream looks like today — its scale, the range of issues it addresses, the geographies it operates in, and the nature of the partnerships and community you've built?

Vishal Talreja: Sure. Dream a Dream today is a 26-year-old organisation. As you mentioned, we work with about 2.2 million children across seven states in India, with a team of just over 100 people — about 104. We partner with state governments to introduce life-skills curricula, or pedagogical approaches that integrate life skills within the school calendar, and to help transform assessment systems from traditional standardised testing toward more formative assessments that let governments track a child's development over the course of their schooling.

Alongside that, we continue to work with about 7,000 students directly in Bangalore. This is our innovation lab — where we bring in new pedagogical approaches, test other studies, and pilot our impact tools; where we explore how life skills develop through the use of clay, art, and different behavioural sciences. Whatever insights come out of this direct work with young people in Bangalore then feed into our work with state systems. And finally, we believe education is at a point where its core purpose needs to be challenged — why children go to school, and what they actually get out of it, needs to shift. So we invest in research too. We're one of the few practitioner organisations with a 14-member research team. We build and seed narratives across the education ecosystem, and we invest in building collaborative investment in education more broadly.

Neharika Vohra: Very interesting. You mentioned 7,000 children you work with directly — and then, of course, many more through schools. Two questions on that: when you work with schools, is it a one-time intervention or a multi-year one? And what's the difference between your after-school life-skills programme and the Career Connect programmes you run?

Vishal Talreja: When we work with schools or communities, it's always a long-term engagement — an average of seven years with a child, sometimes stretching to 13 or 14 years. We start working directly with children as young as six, and continue with some until they're 24 or 25. Children can enter our programme at any age, which makes the design fairly unique.

The after-school programme runs in partnership with local schools in Bangalore — government schools, charity-run schools, and affordable private schools — using a pedagogical approach built around play and art to help children develop life skills, typically once a week, starting from grade two or three and going up to grade ten. What we came to realise is that life-skills development is a lifelong process, not something you can complete in three years and then be "ready." So when children turn 14 or 15 — right when school is ending for many of them, especially those from vulnerable and marginalised backgrounds — they're making major life and career decisions. A lot of them drop out to work, or because of social and cultural norms in the family, or because they need to look after younger siblings at home. That's exactly the moment they need life skills the most — it's where the real transition from adolescence to adulthood happens.

That's what our Career Connect centres are for — youth centres in Bangalore communities where young people, even those who've dropped out of school, can come to explore their identity and their choices, join relevant skilling programmes, access

mentors, and pursue scholarships if they want to continue — not just in education, but in vocational courses or creative pursuits too. From there, we help them transition into an adult environment where they're more capable of making decisions for themselves.

Neharika Vohra: Are these exploratory spaces supervised or unsupervised?

Vishal Talreja: There's a team of facilitators present. The way we've designed these spaces, working closely with young people themselves, is that they come and simply hang out — in many communities, these are the only spaces where young people feel safe. They can watch a movie, read, play board games, catch up with friends, even celebrate a birthday. There are also private rooms where they can sign up for structured programmes — computers, financial literacy, communication skills, and a range of other life-skills courses. As they grow older, we also connect them to vocational skills — baking, jewellery-making, learning to use Tally software — based on what young people themselves tell us they want to learn, and we bring in external partners to run those courses.

Neharika Vohra: You've come a long way since 1999, when a group of twelve young people — some of whom gave up thriving careers — started this as a voluntary weekend initiative. It's now a nationally recognised organisation shaping state government curricula. Could you walk us through some of the turning points along the way, and also tell us how many people work at Dream a Dream today and what kind of work they do?

Vishal Talreja: There have been a few significant turning points. The first was right at the beginning, when the twelve of us — fresh graduates just starting our careers — came together. None of us set out to build a nonprofit; we started Dream a Dream simply to have more meaningful weekends, a way to give back to the community. Over the first two years of running it as a voluntary effort, we began to understand the real complexity of the challenges children growing up in marginalisation face. I personally became deeply invested in understanding that complexity, and increasingly convinced that a purely voluntary effort wasn't going to solve it. So after two years, I left investment banking to work on this full-time. In those early years, the big question was: what does the organisation actually bring, as value, to people's lives?

We recognised that in many of the care homes and communities we served, children's basic needs — food, clothing, shelter, access to education — were being met. But they didn't have the skills and capacities to deal with the complex challenges of their lives. That's when we identified life skills as our core intervention — the first major milestone: recognising that children needed life skills not just for their present challenges, but to build capacity for future ones.

The second milestone was understanding child development. As we developed our after-school programmes using sport, art and other media, we noticed a range of behavioural patterns — restlessness, a propensity toward violence, extreme shyness, children who'd show up one day and vanish the next. To understand what was happening, we began working with child and mental health psychologists, who introduced us to the concept of "failure to thrive." Every child, from infancy, moves through a set of developmental milestones — a child in a cradle doesn't suddenly start running; they learn to turn, then crawl, then stand, then walk, then run, in the same broad sequence everywhere in the world. But adversity — neglect, hunger, extreme poverty, abuse, violence — can cause children to miss the sensitive periods when those milestones are meant to be achieved, and after that, they're simply playing catch-up. If we don't help them catch up, that shows up as failure to thrive — sometimes physically, in height and weight, and sometimes mentally and emotionally. Research shows that nine out of ten children who experience abuse in early childhood are likely to face mental health challenges later on.

That was our second breakthrough — recognising that we also needed to help children build the life skills to catch up on developmental milestones they'd missed, so they could return, in effect, to the sensitive periods where real development happens.

The third milestone came around 2010, ten years in, when we'd scaled our direct work to reach about 10,000 children. We were asking ourselves what came next — whether to keep doing the same thing, or find a leverage point to reach more children. The insight, interestingly, came from the children themselves. We asked them why they came to Dream a Dream programmes, expecting them to say it was for the sports or the art, or the snacks. Instead, they told us they came because they felt cared for — because of the dignity they experienced in how the facilitators treated them. That was the insight: what children were really seeking was a safe space, built on identifiable principles. We unpacked those principles and asked whether we could help other adults in the ecosystem — teachers, youth workers, facilitators in other organisations — unlock that same empathy, care, non-judgement, creativity and dignity in their own relationships with children, so we wouldn't have to reach every child ourselves; we could enable the wider ecosystem to reach them instead. That's when we began working with the education sector directly — the big milestone of 2010.

Then in 2018 came the next major shift: we started working with government. It took us eighteen years to build the capacity and the confidence to approach government with a solution we believed could work for every child. We were fortunate to be working

with the Delhi government at a moment when a new political administration had come in on a mandate of education reform. They came to us wanting to change the relationship between the child, the school and the teacher — from one rooted in fear to one rooted in care and safety. That partnership, alongside several others, led to the design and launch of the Happiness Curriculum — a genuinely radical shift, given how sacrosanct the Indian school calendar is normally treated. For the first time, a new class was added — a 35-minute Happiness class, every day, for every student from kindergarten to grade eight, built around storytelling, mindfulness, brain-based activities and artistic expression to help children invest in their own well-being. Teachers who taught mathematics, languages and the sciences also became Happiness teachers. That breakthrough taught us how to work within government systems and how to reform education from inside them — and it opened the door to expanding our programme across several more states.

Neharika Vohra: That's how you eventually went to states like Jharkhand. Are these programmes still running within government systems, or have some been discontinued?

Vishal Talreja: In the seven states we work in, the programmes are still running, though they look quite different from state to state — even in Delhi, the programme has been renamed, but it continues in the way it was originally designed. Each state's version is built around that state's own context; it isn't a standard programme we simply replicate. When we start working with a new state, we typically spend almost a year understanding the local context, needs and challenges — Jharkhand's needs are fundamentally different from Telangana's — before co-designing something with the local education system, centred on life skills, child safety, well-being and holistic learning.

Neharika Vohra: How do you fund all of this, Vishal? Clearly some of this work can't be self-sustaining — you must depend on others. How is it funded?

Vishal Talreja: We're supported largely by institutional donors — mostly international donors, family foundations, grant-making bodies, and some CSR donors in India who fund the design and implementation of these programmes. The government doesn't pay us anything for our partnership with it — that's a deliberate choice we've made, not to ask the government for money. But we do work to unlock government spending on these curricula and teacher trainings as part of the education budget — so while I might invest twenty rupees of my own capacity, I'm also working to unlock another eighty rupees from the government's own budget for the programme.

Neharika Vohra: And with funders involved, there's likely some tension — someone suggesting one direction, someone else insisting their money would be better spent elsewhere. How do you manage that?

Vishal Talreja: It took some real work with funding agencies over the years. One thing we've stayed firm on is that Dream a Dream will always be focused on life skills — so we sought out funders aligned with that, and if a funder wanted us to do something different, they simply weren't the right partner for us. We built the internal conviction to walk away if needed. At the same time, we've worked hard alongside our funders to help them understand why life skills matter as an education intervention — sometimes it's taken years to convince a donor this is the right investment. Today we have about eight to ten donors who've stayed with us for anywhere between three and ten years; we've been through the ups and downs, the failures and the successes together. Over that journey, they've influenced our thinking, brought more rigour into our impact and evaluation practices, and in turn we've shifted their thinking about what genuinely helps children thrive in the long run — it's become a mutually respectful partnership. What's also helped is that we've deliberately stayed a small organisation. Our budget has held steady at around 20 to 25 crore rupees for the last eight years, raised through these eight to ten funders — which has put real pressure on us to find more leverage from the same amount of money. Eight years ago I had one government partnership; today, with the same budget, I have seven.

Neharika Vohra: And what's the size of your team, Vishal?

Vishal Talreja: About 103 or 104 people.

Neharika Vohra: And of those 104 — how long do they tend to stay? What's your attrition been like, and what are the challenges around motivating and attracting talent?

Vishal Talreja: In our first ten or twelve years, we genuinely struggled with talent and with integration — we were losing nearly 40% of the team every year. Some of that was a reflection of my own lack of leadership experience; I started at 21 with no background in building teams or organisations, and made plenty of mistakes early on. But over the last 13 or 14 years, we made a fundamental shift in the culture of the organisation, investing in what we call our "people philosophy," which has worked very well. Our attrition has stayed under 10% year-on-year for at least the last ten to twelve years, which means most of our team has now been with us for between five and ten years. Interestingly, 40% of our team today are graduates of our own programme —

young people who came through Dream a Dream, became adults, and joined the organisation, from frontline roles right up to leadership.

Neharika Vohra: I'd love to hear more about that people philosophy, and how it's helped you retain people.

Vishal Talreja: The core idea was: how can we, as an organisation, be representative of the very work we're doing with young people? If we're helping young people build the capacity to thrive in a fast-changing, complex world, then Dream a Dream itself needs to be an empowering ecosystem for its own staff, so that each of us can thrive too. That pushed us to rethink how culture actually gets translated into systems and policy. One example: we've done away with annual appraisals entirely. Instead, whenever an individual feels ready, they can carry out a self-reflection exercise, gather feedback from peers and managers, and decide for themselves whether they're ready to move to the next level — not on a fixed promotion cycle, but based on readiness to take on more responsibility and accountability. A higher salary comes with that, but only once someone has genuinely built the capability for it.

The other major shift was setting a rule that the salary range from the most junior role to the highest-paid person in the organisation can never exceed 10x. So if we want to raise the top leadership's salary, we have to raise the entry-level salary too — which builds a real sense of dignity in pay across every level. These are just a couple of examples, but there's a whole redesigned system underneath them, built around empowerment, self-accountability, dignity for every role, and trust — and that combination is really what's driven attrition down, while also giving people a genuine sense of ownership over when and how they grow.

Neharika Vohra: I like that you mirror what you teach children within the organisation itself. You mentioned that 40% of your people are past students — are there integration challenges there, given they may come from very different backgrounds than colleagues who join with more privilege?

Vishal Talreja: That's a great question, because yes, we genuinely do. People come from different caste and class backgrounds, different identities, religions, and languages. In our early years, being a largely urban organisation, we hired mostly from middle-class backgrounds, and English was effectively the organisation's primary working language. As we began hiring more graduates from our own programme, the working language shifted toward Kannada — and today, because we work across several states, every meeting genuinely involves a mix of English, Hindi and Kannada. Every time we've encountered this kind of tension, it's forced us to pause and understand what needed to shift in our culture — always coming back to the principle that if you want to build a society where every individual's life experience is treated with dignity and respect, you have to build that first inside your own organisation. That's meant a lot of internal work unpacking our own prejudices and biases. For example, for the first ten years I never examined my own identity through that lens — today I recognise myself as an upper-caste, upper-class, cisgender, privileged Hindu man in a leadership position, and I've had to ask what choices I've made, because of those identities, that made someone else invisible or held them back. One recognition, years ago, was that my own patriarchal upbringing had left me a poor listener for women's voices within the organisation — I had to actively work on that bias. Each of us has had to do the same kind of work: unravel our own identities and biases, and see what needs to shift as a result. Doing that collectively, in a safe internal culture, has made it much easier for us to actually talk about it.

Neharika Vohra: That's very interesting, and I think genuinely deep — in some of my own work I often say that, at the end of the day, a leader has only themselves as an instrument, and that instrument has to stay in tune, which is only possible through this kind of inner work. You're showing us what that looks like in practice, and it's clearly shaped the culture of the organisation.

That's a good segue into a related question. Life skills, durable skills, "future of work" skills — there are many names for this now, and everyone is talking about it, but doing it at scale is genuinely difficult, because in some sense this is exactly what school and college education should already be doing. How do you see it as an add-on versus something truly integrated?

Vishal Talreja: We have to look at this challenge on multiple levels. First, we try not to get caught up in the language — 21st-century skills, future skills, whatever the label. Life skills were relevant in the 18th century, and they're relevant in the 21st; they look different, and help us navigate different complexities, but the underlying need doesn't change.

Second — while we started out treating life skills as an add-on, we've come to see them as foundational. When a four-year-old from a marginalised background, perhaps a first-generation school-goer, enters school for the first time without the basic ability to pay attention or concentrate, that child is going to struggle regardless of how good the teacher is, if the foundation of how to learn simply isn't there. Add to that a classroom of forty children with diverse identities, castes, religions and languages, plus whatever biases the teacher themselves might bring, plus the structural barriers of an underinvested system, and the barriers compound quickly.

To address that, we first have to build the child's own capacity to engage with learning. There's rightly a big national focus on foundational numeracy and literacy — every child should have those basics — but building the ability to actually acquire literacy and numeracy requires life skills in the first place. Our very first experience of sustained attention, in a supportive family, is usually a parent or grandparent telling us a bedtime story — that's when the brain starts wiring for attention, association, and engagement. But if you've grown up in a slum community in Bangalore, where both parents are working, there are no grandparents around, and a nine-year-old sibling is looking after you, that early scaffolding often isn't there — and school becomes the child's first real learning environment, even though the school itself isn't designed for that diversity of need.

So we've come to see life skills as foundational to learning itself — skills for life, as the name suggests. If I ask you to think back to your own childhood and name a handful of experiences that left a deep impression, you won't remember a hundred — you'll remember two or three, because those are the ones that were genuinely transformative, the ones the body itself builds a kind of muscle memory around. For me, some of my most important memories come from the sports field, and even today, when I'm struggling with something, I can go back to a conversation with my coach and draw strength from it. If I ask you to summon a memory like that right now, something shifts in your body immediately — that's the point: the first transformative experiences of childhood happen in the body, and the question becomes what experience we're creating for a child — one of discrimination and othering, or one of dignity, respect, and mattering. That experience stays with a child for life, and that's what life skills build: the ability to keep meeting life's challenges as they grow and as the complexity increases. That's why we've stayed committed to life skills as foundational for the last twenty years — and why, when we work with policymakers today, the goal is to integrate life skills as a foundational element of education, not an afterthought.

Neharika Vohra: Very nice, thank you for sharing that. You're currently a member of the OECD's Future of Education 2030 project, and have contributed to global education policy. Could you tell us about that, and how you see your work fitting into and being amplified by that engagement?

Vishal Talreja: We sort of stumbled into this as we started getting global recognition for our research, pedagogy and curricula, and began getting invited into these forums. What we noticed was that in many countries, conversations around education had already started shifting toward whole-child learning, holistic development, and well-being — India is still catching up to that idea, in some ways by almost two decades. Platforms like the OECD gave us a window into those conversations — how other countries were rethinking the purpose of education, and designing it for the future. Some OECD countries have done remarkably well shifting the core purpose of education — the Scandinavian countries, but also newer entrants like Estonia — and that gave us a way to bring some of those learnings back into the Indian ecosystem, not just at Dream a Dream, but more broadly among organisations and policymakers working on education transformation here.

But the bigger learning for us was that in many of these global rooms, you're often one of just one or two people of colour present, and the conversations are largely designed around a global-north context — not the global majority, where the biggest challenges in learning, and the largest child populations, actually exist. Many of these spaces simply don't have a working concept of childhood adversity and its impact on a child's ability to thrive, so global education policy is often being designed without that context in view. That gave us an opportunity to bring our own research, ground-level insights, and impact studies directly into that conversation, and to help these institutions design policy that's genuinely integrated with context like ours. That's how the relationship developed further — not just with the OECD, but with the Harvard Graduate School of Education, and WISE, a programme of the LEGO Foundation, globally. Today we see ourselves not just as learners absorbing insight from the global north, but as genuine contributors to that narrative — as a source of breakthrough insight they don't otherwise have.

Neharika Vohra: What are one or two specific things you learned over the last twenty years that you were able to bring into those global conversations, beyond just context?

Vishal Talreja: One was around how to create change at scale. When people talk about creating change in a country like Finland, they're often talking about fewer than a million children total; when I talk about Delhi alone — one of our smaller states — that's two million children. Our ability to design systems, models and partnerships that create change at that kind of scale has been one genuinely important contribution we've been able to offer elsewhere.

The second example: Finland has a largely homogeneous population, which historically made designing education relatively straightforward. But over the last couple of decades, as I learned speaking with their Secretary of State for Education, they've begun receiving migrant children from Syria, Sudan, Bangladesh, Nepal and India — children with very different identities and traumas — and their education system wasn't designed for that kind of diversity. We were able to bring in our own pedagogical approaches to working with children across diverse identities and traumas, and share that experience with the Finnish system. Something similar happened with Portugal — I was working with their Ministry of Education through the OECD project, and their challenge was that as their youth population grew, they were struggling to build the right employability skills. We were able

to connect them with Indian organisations working specifically on school-to-work transition and youth employability, so they could learn from approaches designed at scale for a country like India.

This cross-fertilisation — learning now flowing from the global majority toward the global north — has been a genuine shift for us, and a reminder that we have something real to contribute. And there's a practical benefit too: once you gain that kind of global recognition, the Indian education system itself starts taking you more seriously, and other doors open more easily.

Neharika Vohra: Sadly true, but true nonetheless. And it echoes something I've come to believe — that one of our unconscious strengths as a nation is our ability to work with diversity, and the more we can unpack that and share it globally, the greater our contribution across many fields, including education. Does Dream a Dream also engage in advocacy with states or other groups? What's that experience been like?

Vishal Talreja: We don't call it advocacy — we call it "building the field." That came from recognising that Dream a Dream, as a small organisation with limited resources, shouldn't be trying to solve this problem alone; instead, we should invest in the wider ecosystem. Twenty-five years ago, when we started working on life skills, it was a very new language — the UN and WHO used the term only in the context of youth affected by HIV or substance abuse, not in education more broadly. Today, most new nonprofits working in this space already carry the language of life skills and social-emotional learning as part of their core vocabulary, rather than arriving at it after a decade of work — even organisations focused primarily on numeracy and literacy outcomes now build in a life-skills component.

That shift in common language has been one big contribution. The second is research: there's a fair amount of research from a Western context, but very little from an Indian one, so we've invested in producing and publishing open-source research papers, policy papers, impact studies and evaluation tools that the wider ecosystem can draw on — research that lets other organisations go to their partners or state governments and say, here's evidence this works, or here's why this problem is more complex than it looks and needs to be approached differently. The third is collaboration — a word that can cut both ways, but for us it's helped create a genuinely shared purpose. Part of that has meant challenging the very definition of the purpose of education, moving beyond a narrow focus on academic outcomes and financial independence, because that narrative simply doesn't work for the majority of our children — it's become, in a sense, a failed narrative.

The new narrative we use is "thriving" — human flourishing, an expanded version of what success in education is meant to mean. That came out of an ethnographic study we did with two alumni of our own programmes, who told us thriving, for them as adults, wasn't just financial independence — that was one piece, but far from the whole picture. It also meant having access to a safe place to live, to basic services like food, water and electricity, to job markets, to safe communities, to the ability to contribute to your neighbourhood as a citizen beyond just voting, and to a support system to lean on in a crisis. That expanded definition helped us rethink what we mean by success — because not every child reaches financial independence on the same timeline; for some it might take twenty years, for others forty, and for some it might be the next generation before it happens. But there are all these other dimensions of thriving — dignity, safety, respect — that we were missing by focusing narrowly on income alone.

Through this collaborative work, that language and understanding of thriving has now made its way into the wider ecosystem — policymakers use it, the National Education Policy of 2020 references it, and the state governments we work with are beginning to treat thriving as a core purpose of education. New research is also increasingly framing thriving not just at the individual level, but at the family, societal and even planetary level — a whole spectrum from the individual to the planet. That's become a substantial part of our work now; almost 40% of our leadership team's time goes into this kind of field-building.

Neharika Vohra: That's an important point too — that it's the codification of field insight, through research and writing, that actually shifts the broader narrative for people who haven't had your twenty years on the ground. That's its own form of leadership. Looking back over those twenty years, what are you genuinely happy about, and what are one or two regrets? And I'd also like to hear about your future plans.

Vishal Talreja: I find it genuinely difficult to answer what I'm happy about, because the work isn't finished — that's part of the challenge social-sector workers face in finding optimism in this kind of work. Of course, there are the hundreds and thousands of young people who've come through Dream a Dream and are thriving in their own ways — we've written up quite a few of those stories. But what I'm most proud of is that the education system in the country is beginning to recognise that every child matters, regardless of background — that every child deserves an education rooted in safety, dignity and respect, and that achieving that requires us, as adults, to shift our own systemic biases and prejudices, because the children were never the problem — we were. That recognition beginning to take hold is what I'm proudest of.

The flip side of the same coin became painfully clear during Covid. When the lockdown hit, overnight, twenty years of gains with young people came undone — they lost jobs, lost family members, couldn't access healthcare, in some cases couldn't even access a dignified burial or cremation for someone they'd lost. That was deeply humbling for us, because we realised we'd been operating largely through a lens of empowerment — the belief that if every child had the right life skills, they'd find a way through. Covid showed us the other side of that story: the systemic barriers created by identity, class and religion, which have only deepened in India given rising polarisation. Our work can't stop at building individual capacity — it also has to address the biases and prejudices baked into the systems themselves. That's been a major focus of ours over the last four or five years, and it's a challenge we're still working through.

Neharika Vohra: In 2023, you founded the Cocoon Initiative, which helps civil-society leaders take sabbaticals — an unusual and, I think, genuinely generous act of leadership care. Could you tell us more about it?

Vishal Talreja: I could talk about it for hours, but the short version comes from my own experience with burnout and extreme fatigue. When I entered the social sector, no one taught me how to deal with trauma, grief, or loss — I came in with joy, purpose and drive, which is wonderful, but along the way, as you lose young people to substance abuse, to police violence, to systemic failures beyond anyone's control, I took a lot of that personally — as a personal failure, a personal loss — and I didn't know how to process it. That eventually led to a breakdown and depression; I was diagnosed in 2018. That was the first time I understood this wasn't just an individual struggle but a systemic one — many leaders in India's social sector, some of whom have given entire careers of twenty, thirty, forty years to this work, never get the support they need to take care of themselves through their own ups and downs. Many have lost connection with their own families, having worked seven days a week for decades, and don't have anyone to talk to about what they're carrying. During Covid, speaking with peers across the sector, I realised many of them were living through the same kind of overwhelm — watching decades of work toward justice and equity come undone almost overnight.

That's what led me to start the Cocoon Initiative. It's really just a small piece of a much larger need — the idea that you can take three months, six months, even a year away from the work to rest, to celebrate the journey you've had, to step back, take a holiday with your family, go on a retreat, get the health check-ups you've been putting off, go to therapy if you need it, or simply sleep. The sabbatical support is primarily financial — covering living expenses for the period, so leaders don't have to worry about that while they rest and recover. Since 2023, we've supported 44 leaders through a full sabbatical and back, with another 17 currently on one.

Neharika Vohra: That's remarkable — and it's a form of taking care of each other across the sector. Last question: I'm assuming you're not thinking about stepping away yet — you're still giving direction to the organisation, so I won't ask you the succession question directly, but I'd be glad to hear any thoughts on it before my very last question.

Vishal Talreja: Actually, I already transitioned out of the CEO role. We had a CEO transition in 2018, and Sujata Bhatt has now led the organisation for eight or nine years. A great deal of the reform we've talked about today — the government partnerships, the cultural shift, the work on systemic inequity — has really been Sujata's vision, not mine; my role has been to champion and support it. Since that leadership transition, I've continued to stay involved because the organisation's vision continues to inspire me. I spend two days a week at Dream a Dream — I sit on the board, and I also report to the CEO on certain areas, mainly field-building and collaborative work, which is a genuinely new arena for me and keeps pushing me beyond an organisational focus toward a broader mission focus. The Cocoon Initiative takes up another two days of my time. And I've deliberately slowed down — I now spend a lot of my own time on health and well-being, which remains a big part of my own healing process, as well as supporting other leaders through theirs. That's roughly where I am right now.

Neharika Vohra: Thank you. For our listeners — especially younger ones who might be considering a career in education, youth development, or the social sector more broadly, whatever their academic background — do you have any specific advice for them?

Vishal Talreja: This might run against the popular advice out there. Whether you join an existing organisation or start your own, spend the first four or five years simply understanding the problem — don't rush to a solution. Work on solutions along the way, of course, but stay focused on the problem itself, and keep asking what it actually is. Problems in this space have complex, layered structure — the moment you think you've understood one layer, you'll discover another six months or a year later. The popular advice today is to go straight for a solution, scale quickly, and become a large organisation within three to five years — and that simply doesn't work. You end up solving the wrong problem, and doing more harm than good in the communities you're trying to serve, because your solutions are half-baked. The only genuine way to address complex challenges in this country — whether in education, livelihoods, or human rights — is to stay with the problem. The solutions emerge from that.

Neharika Vohra: That's great advice — there's little use solving a problem you haven't truly understood. Thank you so much, it was wonderful talking with you, Vishal. I hope you continue this work, and that we get to collaborate with you again.

Vishal Talreja: Thank you, Professor Vohra. I really enjoyed the questions, and this whole conversation. Take care.

Neharika Vohra: Thank you. Thank you.